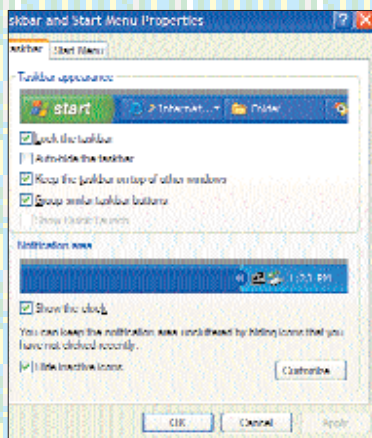




Ungrouping the taskbar items

because Windows XP, by default, enables the option for grouping similar programs on the taskbar. To uncheck this option, right-click on a blank area of the Taskbar and select Properties. Under Properties, deselect 'Group Similar Taskbar Buttons', and then click OK.

If you want to specify the number of windows before Windows XP groups the program windows, you will have to navigate to the registry key `HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Explorer\Advanced\TaskbarGroupsize`. Now right-click on Taskbar Groupsize and change the hexadecimal value to whatever you like (for example, 4 or 5 or even 10). XP will now group the programs according to the number you set.

Hiding inactive icons

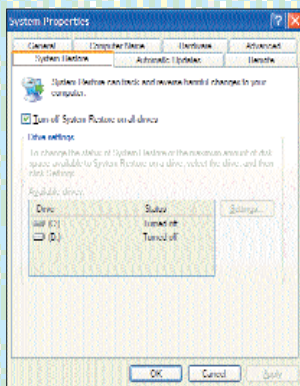
After installing Windows XP, if you log on to the Internet

and surf for a while, you'll find that your Internet icon has disappeared. This is not an indication that you have been disconnected; it merely means the icon is hidden since it's been lying idle in the System tray. If you so wish, you can disable this option by right-clicking on the Taskbar, choosing Properties, and disabling the 'Hide Inactive Icons'

option. You can specify the ones you would not like to be hidden.

Disabling Automatic Windows Update and System Restore

There are certain services such as Windows Update and System Restore, which are automatically loaded and occupy a lot of space. If you would like to disable them, right-click on My Computer and choose Properties. Click on the System Restore tab



Disable the System Restore feature

and check the box 'Turn off System Restore'. This will increase Windows performance and save disk space.

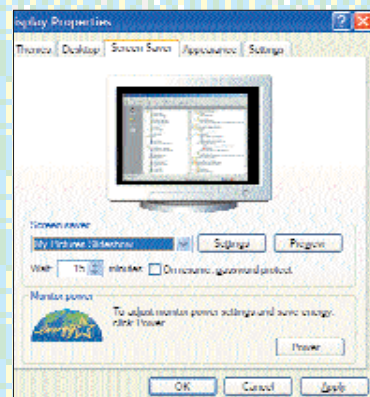
Similarly, locate the 'Automatic Update' option just next to 'System Restore'. This option will periodically ask you to update the OS. You can go ahead and disable this, but remember that you will have to update Windows manually after applying this option since there will be no reminders.

Change the picture on the welcome screen

Want to add your own picture in the Startup menu? Well, who wouldn't? Here is how you go about doing it. Go to **Start > Control Panel User account > Administrator**. There you will see an option to change the picture on the welcome screen. On clicking it, you will see an option from which you can select the picture already present or you can browse to the folder where you've saved your photograph.

Creating personal screensavers

You can use your photographs for creating slide show presentations or even creating a screensaver. Right-click an empty spot on your desktop, choose Properties, and click the Screensaver tab. In the Screensaver list, click



Use images to create your own personal screensaver

on 'My Pictures Slideshow', and click 'Settings' to make any adjustments such as how often the pictures should change, their size and whether you would like to use transition effects between pictures. Click OK to finish. The screensaver that will now be generated will display photographs from the My Pictures folder in a random manner.



View Images as Filmstrip

Windows XP makes things easier by allowing you to view all images in one go. But in order to do that you will have to go to the folder where the images are stored and then go to **View > Filmstrip**. The images will be neatly arranged in a straight line just like a filmstrip thus letting you preview each one of them.